

have used large catapults to hurl rocks, as well as the *rathamusala*, a chariot fitted with a mace that scythed through the enemy's ranks. From the early 5th century BCE, the empire-building Nanda dynasty could deploy armies consisting of 20,000 cavalry and 200,000 chariots, as well as 3,000 war elephants, which the Greeks encountered for the first time when Alexander the Great's army invaded India in 327BCE.

HORSEBACK RAIDERS

From the 2nd century BCE, Indian dynasties lost territory in the north of the country to Central Asian nomadic groups such as the Yuezhi, and

later the Sakas and Hunas. Horse-mounted bowmen, these warriors could travel rapidly, enabling them to carry out successful campaigns of harassment against Indian forces of greater number. The established Asian powers, with their more conventional military tactics, found these offensives difficult to repel. In China, the Han engaged in a long-running struggle against the nomadic Xiongnu people to the north-west, who several times during the 2nd century BCE seized control of the strategic Tarim Basin. They and many other tribes continued to plague the Chinese along the whole frontier of their empire well into the 5th century CE.



▲ TERRACOTTA ARCHER

Often aristocratic warriors, archers formed the elite of Chinese armies, until the rise of elite infantry and weapons such as the crossbow, which occurred during the Warring States period (403–221BCE).

“Let your rapidity be that of the wind, your compactness that of the forest. In raiding and plundering, be like fire”

SUNZI, THE ART OF WAR, 500CE



◀ EPIC BATTLE

A scene from the Mahabharata, an ancient Indian epic recounting a struggle between two armies over the Delhi area that ended in an 18-day battle.

KEY EVENTS

2600–100BCE

■ **c. 1000BCE** The legendary Mahabharata War between the Kauravas and Pandavas is the first conflict described in Indian history.

■ **221BCE** After a long series of wars, the Qin kingdom under Qin Shih Huangdi conquers the last of the other Warring States, making China a unified country ruled by an emperor for the first time.

■ **261BCE** Mauryan forces kill around 100,000 Kalingan soldiers in a bloody battle during the conquest of Kalinga (in modern Orissa, India). The victorious Mauryan ruler, Ashoka, renounces war and turns to the non-violent creed of Buddhism.

■ **202BCE** At the Battle of Gaixia, the Chinese Han army under Liu Bang traps the rival Chu force under Xiang Yu in a canyon, killing most of them. Soon after, Chu surrenders, and Liu Bang becomes the first Han emperor.

■ **127BCE** General Wei Qing invades the Xiongnu lands north of the Chinese frontier, beginning a Han–Xiongnu war that carries on intermittently until 89CE.